

KRISTA DOTZENROD

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Backend Engineer

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Results-driven Backend Engineer with ~7 years of experience designing and delivering robust, scalable services in fast-moving product companies. Skilled in building backend infrastructure, data pipelines, and AI-augmented platforms leveraging LLMs, code generation tools, and intelligent automation to accelerate development velocity and time to production. Passionate about user-centric products, ethical AI, and leading cross-functional teams from ideation through production. Proven history at companies including Spotify, Accenture and Target.

TECHNICAL SKILLS AND AI TOOLING

- **AI Development Tools:** Claude (Anthropic), ChatGPT, Gemini, Cursor IDE with custom rules
 - **AI Infrastructure:** MCP server integration, Claude Skills development, meta prompt engineering
 - **Code Generation:** AI-assisted development workflows, automated testing with LLM validation
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PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Backend Engineer / Senior Software Engineer

Spotify, New York, NY | Aug 2021 – Current

- Developed core backend services powering S4A internal tooling and streaming personalization, handling millions of monthly active users.
- Architected the systems powering audiobooks expansion for 80m+ eligible users across multiple countries focusing on content personalization.
- Integrated Claude MCP servers to automate backend service documentation generation, reducing manual effort and increasing speed of delivery.
- Implemented AI-assisted code review workflows using Cursor rules, improving code quality metrics and test coverage across team repositories.
- Mentor junior engineers, contributed to hiring and onboarding processes.

- Leading an Observing Working Group that focuses on standardizing, implementing, and adhering to reliability best practices in our backend services including optimizing SLO thresholds and right sizing services in GKE and performing future-proofing exercises like running disaster recovery tests.
- Explored embedding-based personalization systems for internal usage at Spotify, including end-to-end ingestion, inference, and service layer retrieval.

Backend Engineer / Senior Software Engineer

Target, Minneapolis, MN | Sep 2017 – Jan 2021

- Rotated through two full-stack backend teams: inventory management & customer-data pipelines.
- Worked closely with product teams to translate business requirements into scalable services and API endpoints.
- Helped build Target advertising tooling in-house using 3rd party APIs.

Support Engineer / Ad Operations Manager

Sovrn / OAO / Starcom, Boulder/Chicago, CO & IL | 2013 – 2017

- Transitioned from ad-ops to technical engineering support, troubleshooting high-volume programmatic ad platforms.
- Automated tag-matching scripts in JavaScript to streamline operational workflows, freeing up 20+ hours/week of manual work.
- Developed a strong foundation in analytics, tracking, and tag-based ad-tech infrastructure.

EDUCATION

M.S. Software Engineering (Current)

Quantic School of Business and Technology | Remote

M.S. Computer Science

Regis University | Denver, CO

B.S. Marketing (Minor: Management)

Loyola University Chicago | Chicago, IL

PROJECTS & VOLUNTEERING

- **Dating app (side-project):** Building a social-group-based dating prototype using Lovable, Supabase, TypeScript/Capacitor mobile stack, and Google OAuth—highlighting full-stack and backend architecture skills.
- **Florist Inventory System:** Designed a backend schema and REST APIs for a small business (Lily's Florist) managing inventory and orders, demonstrating product mindset and technical versatility.
- **Web Application and Interface Design:** Created and hosted a [website](#) < 2 hours using Claude and Cursor for an MSSE project.
- **Advisor, Women in Leadership with AI-Driven Engagement** (*Minnesota State University, Mankato*)
 - Serve as an advisory board member for a leadership development program integrating AI-driven engagement and personalized learning strategies.
 - Provide guidance on applying AI to enhance participant engagement, learning outcomes, and leadership development across diverse professional backgrounds.
 - Contribute industry perspective on ethical, human-centered AI and its role in shaping modern leadership and decision-making.